

MONCHO UNSCHOOLING

Dance

Unit Study

“Every person on Earth has a body that can tell a story without a single word, and dance is the oldest way we have of doing it.”

Movement & Body | Music | Physics | Biology | Language Arts | Math | History | Geography | Art & Creativity | Life Skills & SEL

By: Alba Nory de González

monchounschooling.com

🧭 **How to use this guide:** This is not a workbook, and there's no answer key — on purpose! Every challenge is an invitation. Pick the ones that spark curiosity, skip the rest, and go find the answers by doing. **AI plans. Kids DO.** 🚀

💃 MOVEMENT & BODY

Your body is the first instrument you ever owned, and with it you can tell a story without saying a single word.

💃 Challenge 1: Foot Position Secret Handshake

🎯 Body Positions

What happens when your feet become the letters of a secret code? ❓

Ballet dancers use five basic foot positions, numbered first through fifth, as the starting point for nearly every movement.

1. Stick five pieces of tape on the floor, each a little apart, so you can see all five at once.
2. Stand on the tape and try each position. First: heels touching, toes pointing out. Second: feet wide apart, toes out. Third: one foot tucked in front of the other, touching at the middle of the foot. Fourth: one foot ahead, with a gap between them. Fifth: feet tight together, one right in front of the other, toe to heel.
3. Choose your three favorite positions and put them in an order only you know.
4. Add a small arm move between each position, like a handshake that uses your whole body.
5. Practice until it flows, then teach it to a family member and perform it together.

Why: Standing in a position builds balance and control, because your brain learns exactly where each foot is without looking.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Try only the first, second and fifth positions, and make your dance two steps instead of three.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Link all five positions in a smooth chain, then try doing them in reverse order without stopping.

💃 Challenge 2: Stomp Like a Team Leader

🎯 Expressive Movement

Can stamping your feet and slapping your chest really change how brave you feel? ❓

You're the leader of a team's pre-game ritual, and everyone is watching you for the first move.

The Maori haka from New Zealand is a traditional group dance with stamping, chanting and strong facial expressions. The "Ka Mate" haka is famously performed by the All Blacks rugby team.

1. Watch a short video of a haka with a family member. Notice the stamping, the chest slaps and the strong faces. The haka belongs to Maori culture, so you'll watch it with respect and build your own team ritual instead of copying it.
2. Invent your own team move: a stamp, a slap on your thighs, and a strong, serious face with wide eyes and a firm mouth.
3. Stand still and notice how you feel. Then do your move again with full power. What changed?
4. Invent one more gesture of your own and teach it to your group.
5. Add a short line to say or chant together, then perform it as a group.

Why: Big, strong movements make your heart beat faster and push your body into an alert state, so you feel more energized and ready.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick just one move, like stamping, and repeat it with a steady beat.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Split your group into two parts, with one calling the chant and the other answering with the movement.

💃 Challenge 3: Design a Warm-Up

🎯 Stretching

Why does a dancer's practice start slowly, long before the exciting moves? ❓

A typical dance class or practice usually begins with a warm-up that stretches and warms up the muscles to help prevent injuries.

1. Think of five stretches that use different parts of your body, such as arms, legs, back, neck and ankles.
2. Put them in an order that goes from gentle to bigger movements.
3. Test your routine on a family member. Hold each stretch for 8 slow counts and breathe calmly.
4. After the last stretch, ask them which muscles feel warm and which stretch was the hardest.
5. Draw your five stretches on a card, then finish with a free dance.

Why: Moving and stretching increases blood flow to your muscles, which makes them warmer and more flexible.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Choose stretches you already know from gym class or sports, and draw only simple stick figures.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Design the routine so it moves from standing to the floor and back up, and add a count of 8 to each stretch.

🎵 MUSIC

Before anyone ever wrote a dance step down, people were clapping, stomping and strumming to tell stories with their bodies.

🥁 Challenge 1: ONE-two-three vs. March!

🎯 Meter and Beat

Why does one pattern make you want to sway while another makes you want to stride? ❓

The waltz was hugely popular in Vienna in the late 1700s and 1800s, and it is danced in 3/4 time: three beats per measure, counted "ONE-two-three."

1. Stomp your foot on ONE, then tap your knees softly on two and three. Repeat ten times without stopping.
2. Now add a clap on two and three: STOMP-clap-clap, STOMP-clap-clap. Say the count out loud as you go.
3. Switch to a march in 4/4: STOMP-clap-clap-clap. Count "ONE-two-three-four" and walk around the room to it.
4. Go back and forth between the two patterns. Which one feels like swaying, and which feels like marching?

Why: The strong first beat repeats every three counts in a waltz, so the pattern keeps "tipping" forward and swirling. In 4/4 it repeats every four, which feels steadier and squarer.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the claps. Just stomp on ONE and whisper "two, three," then do the same with four counts.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make up a 4-measure body-percussion song that switches from 3/4 to 4/4 halfway through, using a stomp, clap, knee tap and snap.

🎸 Challenge 2: Rubber-Band Flamenco

🎯 Layering Rhythms

How can two simple sounds, one clapped and one strummed, become something that feels like a whole performance? ❓

Flamenco comes from Andalusia in southern Spain and combines singing (cante), guitar playing, dance (baile) and handclaps (palmas). UNESCO recognized it as Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2010.

1. Find an open box, like a tissue box or small shoebox, and stretch 4 or 5 rubber bands of different thicknesses across the opening.
2. Pluck each band and listen. The thicker ones sound lower.
3. Clap a steady pattern: clap-clap-CLAP, clap-clap-CLAP. Keep it going until it feels easy.
4. Ask a partner to strum the box on every CLAP while you keep clapping. If you're alone, clap with one hand on your leg and strum with the other.
5. Try clapping soft, then LOUD, to change the mood.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Just clap the pattern with a partner, one person clapping and the other tapping their knees on the big beat.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third layer: stomp your foot on the first clap of each pattern, or hum a short "cante" melody over the top.

🥄 Challenge 3: Conductor of the Kitchen Orchestra

🎯 Timbre and Listening

What does "sparkly" sound like, and which things in your kitchen can make it?❓

The Nutcracker ballet, with music by Tchaikovsky, premiered in Saint Petersburg, Russia, in 1892. You're the conductor of a kitchen orchestra, and you have one piece to prepare: "Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy."

1. Gather 5 or more sound-makers: spoons, glasses (try tapping them gently), a jar of rice or beans as a shaker, a pot lid, a wooden spoon.
2. Listen to the piece once with your eyes closed. Which sounds feel light, tinkly or twinkly?
3. Test each item and sort them: sparkly, soft or low.
4. Play the piece again. Use the sparkly sounds to tap along with the tinkly parts and a soft shaker for the quieter moments.
5. Use your hands like a conductor: big gestures for loud, tiny ones for quiet.

Why: Small, hard objects like glass and metal ring out quickly with high, thin sounds, which our ears hear as sparkly.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick just two instruments, one sparkly and one soft, and play them whenever you hear the music change.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write a "score" using symbols or colors for each instrument, then perform it for a friend or family member while you conduct.

⚙️ PHYSICS

Your body is a moving science lab, and every dancer uses spinning, balancing and sound without even thinking about it.

🌀 Challenge 1: Pirouette Power

🎯 Spinning Motion

What do you think happens to your spin when you change the shape of your body? ❓

1. Sit on a swivel chair (or stand on a smooth floor in socks) with your arms stretched wide. Ask a helper to give you one gentle push, then count how many turns you make before slowing down.
2. Reset. Get the same gentle push, but this time pull your arms in tight against your chest as soon as you start spinning. Count the turns again.
3. Try a third time with one arm out and one arm in. How does the speed feel?
4. Make a spin log: draw a small table with three rows (arms out, arms in, one in and one out) and write down your turns and how fast it felt.

Why: when your arms come in, your weight moves closer to the middle of your body, so you spin faster. Ballet dancers do the same thing in a pirouette.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Just do two spins, arms out and arms in, and draw a happy face for "fast" or a sleepy face for "slow."

🚀 **Level it Up:** Hold a light weight in each hand, like a small water bottle, and compare. Does the speed change get bigger?

⚖️ Challenge 2: The Balance Audition

🎯 Balance and Measuring

Which small change makes standing on one foot the hardest?❓

You're the balance judge at a dance audition, and every dancer must be tested fairly.

1. Grab a stopwatch (or a phone timer) and a partner. Stand on one foot with your arms stretched out to the sides. Your partner times you until your other foot touches down.
2. Test arms down by your sides. Then test arms out while up on tiptoe. Last, test arms out with your eyes closed (stand next to a wall for safety).
3. Do each test twice and write both times on a scoresheet. Circle the best one.
4. Switch jobs and judge your partner.

Why: your brain uses your eyes, your inner ear and your muscles together to keep you upright, so taking away one of them makes balancing wobblier.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Only compare two tests, arms out and arms down, and stand near a chair you can touch.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Try each test on a folded towel or pillow. How much do the times drop on a wobbly surface?

👟 Challenge 3: Stomp, Tap, Slide!

🎯 Sound and Vibration

Why does the same stomp sound so different on different floors?❓

Time to be a sound detective with your own feet!

1. Find four surfaces around your home or yard: carpet, wood, tile and a piece of cardboard.
2. On each surface, stomp once, tap your toe, and slide your foot. Use a hard-soled shoe if you have one.
3. Listen closely. Is it loud or quiet? Sharp or soft?
4. Rank the four surfaces from quietest to loudest and write your list down.

Why: a hard shoe on a hard floor bounces back fast and makes the floor vibrate, which makes a loud clear click. Carpet soaks up that energy, so you hear almost nothing.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Test only two surfaces, carpet and wood, and use just the stomp.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a fifth surface of your choice, then predict its rank before you test it. How close was your guess?

🧬 BIOLOGY

Your body is a living machine, and dance shows you exactly how your heart, your lungs, and even a bee's wiggle all work together.

🫀 Challenge 1: Pulse Before and After

🎯 Heart Rate

What happens inside your chest when your body starts to move? ❓

Dancing is a form of exercise, and exercise raises your heart rate. Kids ages 6-11 usually have a resting heart rate of roughly 70-100 beats per minute. Let's see where yours lands.

1. Sit still for one minute. Press two fingers (not your thumb) on the inside of your wrist, below the thumb, until you feel a gentle thump.
2. Count the beats for 15 seconds, then multiply by 4. Write this number down.
3. Put on a song you love and dance for two full minutes without stopping.
4. Find your pulse again right away, count for 15 seconds, and multiply by 4.
5. Subtract your resting number from your dancing number. How many extra beats per minute?

Why: your muscles use up oxygen fast when you dance, so your heart pumps harder and faster to deliver more oxygen-rich blood to them.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Count your pulse for a full 30 seconds and double it, or just compare "slow thumps" and "fast thumps" without doing any math.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Rest for one minute after dancing and measure again, then keep measuring every minute. How long does your heart take to calm back down to your resting number?

🐝 Challenge 2: The Waggle Dance Treasure Hunt

🎯 Animal Communication

How can a bee tell her sisters exactly where the flowers are without saying a single word? ❓

You're a forager bee who just found a huge patch of flowers! Bees really do tell each other where food is by doing a "waggle dance," and Karl von Frisch won a Nobel Prize in 1973 partly for figuring out this secret code. In the dance, the angle of the waggle shows the direction, and a longer waggle means the flowers are farther away.

1. Pick a partner to be the hive bee. Hide 3 paper "flowers" in different rooms while they close their eyes.
2. Choose a spot in the middle of the house as your "hive." Decide which direction counts as "up" (for example, toward the window).

3. Dance on the floor: waggle your hips while walking in a straight line. Point the line in the direction of your flower, and waggle for just 2 seconds if it's close or 6 seconds if it's far.
4. Your partner follows your directions and tries to find the flower.
5. Switch roles and hunt again.

Why: bees can't talk, so their bodies carry the message, with the dance angle pointing the way and the waggle time showing the distance.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Hide only one flower in the same room, and use just the direction of your waggle without worrying about the length.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Create your own code for the flower's quality, like a fast waggle for a super-sweet flower and a slow one for a so-so flower, then see if your partner can crack it.

🫁 Challenge 3: Lung Detective

🎯 Breathing and Lungs

Where does all that air go when you breathe hard after dancing? ❓

You'll first catch your own breathing in action, then build a lung you can hold in your hands.

1. Sit still for a minute. Count how many breaths you take in 30 seconds (one breath is one inhale plus one exhale), then double it. Write it down.
2. Dance hard to your favorite song for one full minute.
3. Right away, count your breaths for 30 seconds and double it. Write it down.
4. Cut the bottom off a plastic bottle with an adult's help, and cover the cut edge with tape so it's smooth.
5. Push one small balloon inside the bottle through the neck, and stretch its opening over the neck's rim.
6. Stretch a second balloon over the cut bottom, tie a knot in its end, and pull the knot down and then push it back up. Watch the balloon inside fill and empty!

Why: when you pull the bottom down, the space inside gets bigger, so air rushes in and fills the "lung," just like your diaphragm does under your real lungs.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Count your breaths for a full 60 seconds instead of doubling, and just compare "calm breathing" with "fast breathing."

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add labels to your model for the lungs, the diaphragm, and the windpipe, then measure how many breaths you take after 30 seconds of dancing, a full minute, and two minutes.

📖 LANGUAGE ARTS

Dance has its own vocabulary, and every word in it carries a story about where it came from, what it means, and how it feels to say.

📖 Challenge 1: The Ballet Teacher's Word List

🎯 Word Origins

Why do so many ballet words sound French, even when the dancers are speaking another language? ❓

You are a ballet teacher in 1700s France, and your students keep forgetting their steps. You decide to write the words down.

1. Say these three words out loud and try each move: plié (bend), tendu (stretched) and arabesque (one leg lifted behind you, arms reaching out).
2. Look up each one in a French dictionary or online translator. What does it mean in everyday French?
3. Use all three words in one sentence that describes a dance, like "She did a deep plié, then a tendu, and finished in a wobbly arabesque."
4. On a sheet of paper, draw a little picture of each step and write its meaning and origin beside it.

Why: Ballet grew up in the royal courts of France, where teachers wrote the steps down in French, and dancers all over the world still use those same words today.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Do just two words and skip the sentence. Draw each step and write what it means in plain English.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Find two more ballet words, such as jeté or pirouette, and add them to your page. Then invent a short "French-sounding" word for a silly new step and explain what it means.

📖 Challenge 2: Invent a Dance Word

🎯 Word Parts

Can you build a brand new word from tiny pieces, the way dancers once did? ❓

The word "choreography" comes from the Greek words for "dance" (choreia) and "writing" (graphia). That means it literally means "dance writing"!

1. Write "choreography" on a page and draw a line to split it into its two Greek parts. Label each with its meaning.
2. Make a list of other words that end in -graphy, like photography or geography. What do you think -graphy means in each one?
3. Pick a dance step you love, such as a spin, a jump or a wiggle. Mix and match word pieces to invent a brand new word for it.
4. Write your new word on a clean page. Split it into parts and explain what each part means. Teach your word to someone, then ask them to guess the step.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Invent your word by sticking two everyday words together, like "hop" and "twirl" to make "hoptwirl." Explain what your word means.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Invent three words and make a mini glossary. Add the Greek or Latin roots you used (for example, "kinesis" means movement) and a sentence using each word.

📖 Challenge 3: The Dancer Who Couldn't Speak

🎯 Narrative Writing

How would you tell a whole story if you couldn't use a single word? ❓

Bharatanatyam is a classical dance from southern India that tells stories using hand gestures called mudras and expressive eyes and faces. Dancers can show a bird, a river or a sad goodbye without saying anything.

1. Look up two or three mudras online or in a library book. Try copying them with your hands and notice what each one shows.
2. Invent a dancer who cannot speak or write, but has an urgent message to send, like "Danger is coming!" or "I found the lost treasure!"
3. Write a one-page story about this dancer. Include the setting, the problem, and the moment when the dancer finally sends the message by dancing.
4. Choose the most important moment in your story. Use your hands, eyes, face and body to perform it for someone, without speaking, and see if they can guess the message.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write just five sentences for your story. Perform the key moment using only your hands and face.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second character who sees the dance and must figure out the message. Write what they think at each gesture, and whether they get it right or wrong.

➗ MATH

Dance runs on numbers: beats split into fractions, floors measured in meters, and bodies that bend into angles.

🥁 Challenge 1: Fraction Stomp-Clap-Snap!

🎯 Adding Fractions

How many different ways can you build exactly one whole beat out of smaller pieces? ❓

Your body is the instrument. A whole beat is one big stomp. A half beat is two quick claps. A quarter beat is four finger snaps.

1. Cut paper into strips and draw a row of boxes on each: 1 box = a whole, 2 boxes = halves, 4 boxes = quarters.
2. Make rows that add up to exactly one whole beat. A row can mix pieces, such as 1/2 + 1/4 + 1/4.
3. Check each row by adding the fractions out loud.
4. Chain four rows into one rhythm and perform it: stomp wholes, clap halves, snap quarters while you read the strips aloud.
5. Swap strips with someone and try to read and play their rhythm.

Why: fractions with different bottoms, like 1/2 and 1/4, can be added once you see that two quarters fill the same space as one half.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only wholes and halves, and build just two rows before performing.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add eighths (eight quick toe taps) and make a row mixing three different fraction sizes.

📏 Challenge 2: The Stage Manager's Floor Plan

🎯 Area and Perimeter

If you double the length of a dance floor, what happens to the space for dancers? ❓

You're the stage manager, and the dancers need a floor by tomorrow. Your floor must fit a whole group.

1. Use string or masking tape to mark a rectangle on the ground, such as 4 m by 3 m. Use steps or a measuring tape.
2. Measure the length and width.
3. Find the perimeter: add all four sides, or 2 × (length + width).
4. Find the area: length × width.
5. Each dancer needs 1 square meter. How many dancers fit?
6. Sketch your floor plan on paper and label the sides, perimeter, area and dancer count.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a small square floor, 3 m by 3 m, and count the square meters one by one.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Rearrange the string into a new shape with the same perimeter. Does it fit the same number of dancers?

📐 Challenge 3: Angle Freeze Dance

🎯 Measuring Angles

How many different angles can your arms and legs make before the music stops? ❓

Play music and dance. When it stops, freeze in a pose where you can name the angle you're making.

1. Learn the three types: acute (smaller than a square corner), right (exactly a square corner, 90°) and obtuse (bigger than a square corner).
2. Call out a type, such as "obtuse!", and freeze with an arm or leg bent that way.
3. Take a photo of each freeze pose: one acute, one right, one obtuse.
4. Print the photos or open them on a screen and place a protractor on the bend of an elbow or knee. Line one arm of the angle along the zero line.
5. Read the number, then check: is it under 90°, exactly 90°, or over 90°?
6. Label each photo with its measured angle.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the protractor and use the corner of a sheet of paper to check whether each pose is smaller than, equal to or bigger than a right angle.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Find a pose with a straight angle (180°), then a pose where two angles at once add up to 180°.

📜 HISTORY

Long before screens and stages, people told the stories of their times with their bodies, and history is full of dances that show who people were.

📜 Challenge 1: A Dance Invitation from the Sun King

🎯 Court Dance

How would you walk, bow and greet people if everyone at a palace party were watching your every move? ❓

You're a courtier at Versailles, and the Sun King has invited you to dance. Louis XIV, nicknamed the "Sun King," danced in court ballets himself and founded the Académie Royale de Danse in 1661. Put on your best "royal" clothes, such as a scarf, a fancy shirt or a paper crown.

1. Stand tall, chin up, and walk slowly in a square: four steps forward, then turn.
2. Bow: slide one foot back and dip your head. Curtsy: bend your knees with your hands lightly holding your skirt or sides.
3. Count a slow "1-2-3" for every step and keep your arms graceful.
4. Greet a partner with a bow, walk your square together, then bow again to finish.

Why: courtiers moved this carefully because every gesture showed rank and good manners, and the king himself set the example.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the square and walk in a straight line, then bow once at the end.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Invite two or three family members and walk your squares at the same time without bumping into one another.

📜 Challenge 2: Cardboard Floor, Bronx Style

🎯 Cultural Origins

How can a group of young people with no money invent a whole new kind of dance? ❓

Hip-hop dance and breaking (breakdancing) grew out of the Bronx in New York City in the 1970s, and DJ Kool Herc is credited as a founder of hip-hop culture. Dancers often practiced on flattened cardboard boxes, so you will too.

1. Flatten a big cardboard box and lay it on the floor as your dance floor.
2. Toprock: standing up, step side to side to a steady beat, swinging your arms and bouncing your knees.
3. Freeze: pick a pose, such as one hand on the floor and your legs balanced, and hold it still for 3 seconds.
4. Put four toprock steps and one freeze together, then repeat.
5. Talk it over: why do you think kids made up something new instead of copying old dances?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Practice toprock alone for one minute, and make your freeze a simple standing pose.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Invent your own toprock step with a name, teach it to someone, and add a second freeze to your routine.

📜 Challenge 3: Dancers on the Cave Wall

🎯 Ancient Art

Why would people thousands of years ago stop everything to dance together? ❓

Dance is one of the oldest human art forms. Cave paintings such as those at Bhimbetka in India show figures that look like dancers, and dance has been part of ceremonies in cultures around the world for thousands of years.

1. Search for pictures of the Bhimbetka cave paintings with an adult and look at the figures. What are they doing? Who is with them?
2. Guess why people danced together: for a harvest, a hunt, a celebration, or to say thank you?
3. Crumple a sheet of brown paper and smooth it out so it looks like a rock wall.
4. Draw a dance with stick-like figures, using only earthy colors: red, brown, black and yellow.

Why: cave artists made colors from natural materials such as clay and charcoal, which is why their paintings look so earthy.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw just three dancing figures holding hands.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a story to your painting, such as the reason for the dance, and write one sentence beside it explaining what is happening.

🗺️ GEOGRAPHY

Dance is the oldest way people say "this is where I come from," so every dance has an address on the map.

🗺️ Challenge 1: Pin the World's Dances

🎯 Map Reading

If you could drop a pin on every dance in the world, what would the map tell you about the places they came from? ❓

Grab a world map or atlas, a pencil, and some sticky notes or stickers. Pick four dances: flamenco, the haka, tango, and capoeira.

1. Look up each dance's home country (Spain, New Zealand, Argentina, Brazil) and find it on your map.
2. Place a pin or sticker on each country and label it with the dance's name.
3. For each place, find one fact about its climate or landscape, such as hot dry plains, rugged mountains, or a warm coast. Write it on a sticky note next to the pin.
4. Draw a line between the two pins that are farthest apart.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pin only two dances and use an adult's help to find the countries.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add two more dances from places you've never heard of and group your pins by continent.

🧳 Challenge 2: The Dance Passport

🎯 Cultures Around the World

What do you need to pack if your job is to learn dances from all over the planet? ❓

You're a traveling dance ambassador, and your next trip covers four countries. Start with Argentina: the tango grew up in the port cities of Buenos Aires and Montevideo in the late 1800s, and UNESCO recognized it as Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2009.

1. Fold three sheets of paper in half and staple the fold to make a little passport booklet.
2. Pick four countries, with Argentina as one of them.
3. For each country, find out what dancers wear there and draw a small picture of the outfit on its page.
4. Design a stamp for each country with a circle, the country's name, and a symbol.
5. Learn one simple step from each country by watching a short video. Each time you learn a step, add the stamp to the page.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick only two countries and draw just one piece of clothing for each.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write the capital city, the language, and how to say "hello" on each page.

🥁 Challenge 3: Capoeira Crosses the Ocean

🎯 Routes and Migration

How could a dance travel across an entire ocean without a single suitcase? ❓

Capoeira is a Brazilian art form that blends dance, acrobatics and martial arts, with music from a one-stringed instrument called the berimbau. It developed among enslaved Africans in Brazil.

1. Look at a world map and find the Atlantic Ocean, the west coast of Africa, and the coast of Brazil.
2. Sketch the outline of the two continents by hand on a big sheet of paper.
3. Draw an arrow showing the path across the Atlantic from Africa to Brazil, and label the two coasts.
4. Find one video of a berimbau being played. Close your eyes and listen to its twangy sound, then jot down three words to describe it.
5. Step outside, find a clear patch of ground, and sway side to side like a capoeirista, trying to move to the music in your head.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use a printed map and trace the coastlines instead of drawing them freehand.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Find the distance between Africa and Brazil on a map with a scale. An old sailing ship might cover about 200 km a day. Divide to estimate how many days the crossing took.

🎨 ART & CREATIVITY

Dance is a story told by the body, and artists have been trying to catch that story on paper for centuries.

🖍️ Challenge 1: Catch the Dancer!

🎯 Gesture drawing

How can you capture a whole movement in just 30 seconds? ❓

You're a sketch artist at a ballet rehearsal, and the dancers never hold still for long. Ask a family member to be your dancer.

1. Set a timer for 30 seconds. Your dancer freezes in a pose: arms wide, one leg lifted, or curled up small.
2. Draw fast with simple lines. Skip the face and the fingers, and just follow the flow of the body.
3. Switch poses and draw again. Fill one page with 8 quick sketches.
4. Pick your favorite pose and take your time to draw it again, bigger. Add the clothes, the floor, and the stage lights.

Why: quick sketches force your eyes to see the big shape of a movement, like a curve or a stretch, before your brain gets distracted by small details.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use 1 minute per pose instead of 30 seconds, and draw stick figures with a circle for the head.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Ask your dancer to move slowly and sketch while they are still in motion, then try drawing the same pose with your non-drawing hand.

🧵 Challenge 2: Costume Designer at Work

🎯 Design and building

What makes a costume look like a character before the dancer even moves? ❓

You're the costume designer for a new show. Swan Lake, a ballet with music by Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky, premiered in Moscow in 1877, and swans have been dancing in white feathery skirts ever since. Now it's your turn to dress a character.

1. Pick a character: a swan, a fox, a king, a storm, or one you invent.
2. Sketch your design and list the colors and shapes that say who the character is.
3. Gather household items, like flattened coffee filters for tutu layers, an old scarf for a cape, cardboard for a crown or wings, or ribbon and tape.
4. Cut, fold, and tape or tie your pieces together. Try it on and move around. Does it stay put when you spin?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make just one piece, like a headband, a cape, or a pair of wings, instead of a full costume.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second piece that moves in a special way, like a skirt that swishes when you twirl, and test it by dancing in it.

📖 Challenge 3: Flipbook Leap

🎯 Animation

How can a pile of tiny drawings turn into a dancer who leaps? ❓

Your notepad is about to become a tiny movie theater.

1. Grab a notepad with at least 20 pages. Start on the last page, in the bottom corner.
2. Draw a dancer standing still with knees bent, ready to jump.
3. On the next page up, draw the same dancer, but move the body just a tiny bit: knees straighter, arms rising.
4. Keep going, with each page changing only slightly: push off, fly through the air, legs stretched, then come down and bend the knees to land.
5. Flip the pages fast with your thumb and watch your dancer leap!

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw a simple stick figure and make only 10 pages, with bigger changes between each one.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a background that changes too, like a moon rising or a curtain opening, and flip it slowly and quickly to see how the speed changes the dance.

🧠 LIFE SKILLS & SEL

Dance asks you to be brave, take care of your body and share big feelings, and these three challenges practice all of that.

🌟 Challenge 1: The Confidence Round

🎯 Bravery

What happens inside you when you try something that feels scary in front of people who are cheering for you? ❓

Gather your family in a circle in a clear space.

1. Each person quietly picks one dance move they find hard, like a wobbly balance, a big silly shimmy or a fast footwork pattern.
2. Take turns. The mover does their move once, and everyone else cheers loudly, no matter how it turns out.
3. Go around a second time. Anyone can try the move again, or pick a new one.
4. Sit down and talk: What did your body feel like before you moved? What did the cheering do?
5. Together, write a list of what made each person feel brave.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick a move you only find a little bit hard, and let the cheering happen after you finish instead of during.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Try a hard move you have never done before, and ask each person to share one thing they will do this week that takes the same kind of courage.

🦺 Challenge 2: The Safe Dancing Plan

🎯 Planning Ahead

What would a dancer need to think about before the music even starts? ❓

You are the dance safety captain, and your job is to keep everyone's body safe.

1. Check your dance area. Is the floor slippery, bumpy or covered in rugs? Is there enough space to spin with arms out?
2. Decide what feet should wear: socks, bare feet or sneakers. Test each one on your floor and notice which grips best.
3. Choose a 2-minute warm-up everyone will do before dancing.
4. Decide what happens if something hurts: stop right away, tell a grown-up, sit and rest.
5. Write your rules on one page, then hold a family dance party and follow the plan. Afterward, fix any rule that did not work.

Why: a slippery floor means less grip, so your feet slide out from under you, and warm muscles stretch and move more easily than cold ones.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick just three rules, draw a picture for each and skip the writing.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a "dance space check" you do every time, like a pilot's checklist, and teach it to a friend or cousin.

💃 Challenge 3: Feelings Without Words

🎯 Expressing Emotions

Can your body and face show a feeling so clearly that someone else can guess it without a single word?❓

1. Pick four feelings, such as joy, worry, loneliness and pride.
2. Invent one movement for each, using only your body and face. No talking!
3. Perform your four movements for a family member, who guesses each feeling and says what it made them feel.
4. Swap roles.
5. Talk it over: Did the same movement feel different to each of you? What did you notice when someone else showed a big feeling?
6. Make a card with your four feeling words, a quick sketch or note of each movement and one line about how it felt to perform and to watch.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Pick only two feelings and make each movement as big and obvious as you can.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Link your four movements into one short dance that goes from feeling to feeling, and see if your watcher can follow the story.